

The Berlaymont's battle plans

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Presented by Google By GABRIEL GAVIN with ZOYA SHEFTALOVICH GOOD MORNING. I'm Gabriel Gavin, bringing this Friday Playbook to a bleary-eyed Brussels b

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GOOD MORNING. I'm Gabriel Gavin, bringing this Friday Playbook to a bleary-eyed Brussels bubble after a week filled with rentrée parties.

In today's Playbook:

- Brussels is getting serious about security. Capitals are more cautious.
- From plant markets to designer furniture shopping, we have everything you need for a pre-payday weekend.
- Faces in the crowd: Roberta Metsola, Anna-Kaisa Itkonen, Charles de Gaulle, Marie-Agnes Strack-Zimmermann, Jim Hagemann Snabe, Andrew Puzder, Tobias Cremer, Magnus Brunner and more.

On the Brussels Playbook Week Ender Podcast: Are we heading for AI armageddon? Cardinal Michael Czerny, chair of the Vatican's AI Commission, Axel Voss MEP and tech reporter Pieter Haeck weigh in on Europe's approach.

A message from Google: Freddo espresso or flat white? Google has opened Connected Cup, an AI pop-up in the EU Quarter. A temporary coffee and events space. Weekdays 08:00 to 16:00 until 16 October. Explore the programme . Come for the technology; stay for the coffee!

DRIVING THE DAY

BATTLE LINES: EU governments are gearing up for a fight over the Commission's plans to strengthen security across the continent, with capitals bristling at the prospect of any kind of power grab by Brussels.

Action stations: Commission President Ursula von der Leyen is weighing new tools to protect against sabotage and cyberattacks — a key priority for her remaining years in office. But capitals that already have world-leading security and defense institutions, like Paris and Berlin, are resistant to any overreach from the EU, five diplomats involved in the talks told Playbook.

Incoming: The first test comes on Wednesday when the EU executive is expected to put ideas to tackle hybrid threats to ambassadors, with a separate Security Strategy to follow by the end of October. “It’s hard to see France and Germany wanting the Commission to have more power over security,” said an envoy from a different country, granted anonymity to speak frankly.

Wednesday’s discussion comes as Europe searches for ways to tackle the hacking, migration weaponization and explosive drones that have heightened security concerns in recent months. It’s designed to help the EU fill in gaps currently left between NATO and national governments, according to two diplomats and an official briefed on the contents. The upcoming Security Strategy, meanwhile, is expected to label Russia as the main threat to EU security, another three diplomats told Jacopo Barigazzi.

So, what do we do about it? Despite the skepticism from some of their neighbors, smaller countries — particularly those that share borders with Russia — support a far-reaching security overhaul, provided it comes with new money. Latvia, Lithuania and Estonia just this week requested around half a billion euros to strengthen their resilience.

Stay in your lane: “Ultimately, each EU member state decides for itself what contribution it makes in the field of defense,” said Marie-Agnes Strack-Zimmermann, the German MEP who chairs the Parliament’s defense committee. “Nevertheless, a coordinated approach on the part of the EU would be helpful.”

A second diplomat put it more bluntly: “If the EU sticks to its competencies, we will have no problems.” The diplomat said the Commission should have a role supporting innovation, AI and space development, while military needs and operational planning fall under the remit of national governments.

Finding the gaps: “Where do we already have the power in the EU?” is what Brussels should be asking, according to Tobias Cremer, lead EU lawmaker on the common defense market and a member of the Parliament’s NATO delegation. “Where do we have real added value ... where we can quickly make a real difference?”

“You work with people on defense, you don’t tell them how to defend themselves,” said a senior EU official, who argued the Commission would earn the support of capitals. “If threats fall under NATO, we have no role. But if they fall under member state competencies, there’s more of [a role] for the EU. It’s [also] about threat detection. If Estonia sees something coming over the border, there should be a system so everyone finds out rapidly, rather than everyone finding out from POLITICO.”

BIG AND BREAKING

IN THE TANK: French President Emmanuel Macron has urged the U.S. not to introduce a 90-day ban on diesel exports , which Europeans fear would cripple their economies.

ART OF THE DEAL: Germany should do a deal with Donald Trump to resolve a standoff over drug pricing that risks further degrading the transatlantic relationship, European Parliament President Roberta Metsola told POLITICO’s Stefanie Bolzen.

BUDGET BAGARRE: French far-right presidential candidate Marine Le Pen used yesterday's Playbook Paris Live summit to accuse Ursula von der Leyen of trying to "bypass democracy" by getting the EU budget firmed up before elections next year.

NATO NÉBULEUSE: Le Pen told us she still wants to take France out of NATO's integrated command, but not while Russia is still at war in Ukraine ... and far-left candidate Jean-Luc Mélenchon wants to leave NATO, but insisted Paris would still defend the bloc's borders .

HARDER LINE: European migration ministers and Commissioner Magnus Brunner will meet in Munich tomorrow to discuss further tightening the bloc's migration policy, strengthening Frontex and plans for return hubs, my Berlin Playbook colleagues report.

BERLAYMONT'S AI BRAIN

FLIP THE SCRIPT: The EU should focus less on building the world's best AI models and more on putting the technology to work across Europe's economy , the EU's special envoy for industrial AI urged commissioners at their seminar earlier this month in Tervuren, two Commission officials told Zoya Sheftalovich.

The U.S. and China may be ahead in developing models such as ChatGPT and DeepSeek, but Europe can still use AI to create value, Jim Hagemann Snabe said, according to the officials who were granted anonymity to discuss the confidential meeting.

The game plan: Snabe's team will spend July through December doing "deep work" on AI in different sectors, or "verticals," and on the technology stack — the models, chips and computing capacity underpinning AI. The work covers both how AI is used and the infrastructure needed to support it.

The team will then draft commitments and shape a policy package toward the end of the year, before examining AI's societal effects from January to March 2027 as it prepares a final report and strategy. Its focus will be industrial AI, adoption and strengthening the tech stack.

Snabe's presentation followed a separate seminar a week earlier, on Aug. 28, for the commissioners' heads of cabinet, delivered by a Commission AI expert. Artificial intelligence is "our best bet to re-accelerate productivity growth," the top official told the gathering, according to a copy of the presentation seen by Zoya. The EU's approach should have a "strong bias for action and rapid impact," per the document.

Some of the use cases: Better disease diagnosis and faster treatment, as well as more efficient production, transport and public administration, the expert said. The aim is to shift attention from whether Europe can build the world's leading models to where AI can deliver practical gains across industries and government.

The big questions: Commissioners and their cabinet chiefs should consider what AI can make possible in their policy areas that was previously too costly or out of reach — and which assumptions no longer hold if cognitive work becomes dramatically cheaper, the experts said.

Risks vs. benefits: The push to harness AI comes amid rising alarm that it could escape human control and threaten humanity. At the U.N. General Assembly in New York overnight, Australian PM Anthony

Albanese warned of the “furious pace” of development and urged world leaders to erect more guardrails . Donald Trump will meet top executives from the leading AI companies at the White House Tuesday (after they attended last night’s State Dinner in honor of Xi Jinping), my stateside colleagues report .

The sudden rush of political activity reflects wider unease: In a POLITICO Poll, carried out by Public First, majorities in France, Germany, Spain, the U.K., Canada and the U.S. said there was at least a “moderate” risk of annihilation, Hanne Cokelaere writes.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The U.S. is said to be preparing a 90-day ban on exports of diesel . How big a problem would that create for Europe? In August, the U.S. supplied 420,000 barrels of diesel to EU member countries and the U.K. — that’s more than half of total imports that month, according to data platform Kpler. Germany alone last month imported 30,000 barrels of diesel from the U.S. Since the war in Iran began, diesel imports from Qatar have dried up, according to Kpler, with imports from Kuwait, Oman and the United Arab Emirates also falling. That’s increased reliance on the U.S.

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PROTECTING TREES IS A DIRTY JOB

WOOD YOU BELIEVE IT: The U.S. has a secret weapon in its long-standing bid to shoot down the EU’s controversial Deforestation Regulation — diapers.

Baby bills: Washington’s ambassador to the bloc, Andrew Puzder, is warning counterparts on the continent that their infants’ absorbent undergarments will be getting more expensive as a result of the EUDR (as the regulation is known), which obliges manufacturers to trace the origin of wood pulp back to the source. That’s as cost of living concerns drive discontent at the ballot box.

“EUDR will increase consumer prices without reducing deforestation when inputs — such as wood pulp used in diapers and other personal hygiene products — become more expensive from countries like the U.S. which pose no deforestation risk,” Puzder told Playbook.

Party poopers: It’s not just the U.S. that hates the green rules. Canada, Malaysia and at least five other non-EU countries are fiercely campaigning for the policy to be dropped or pared back. Canada’s Ambassador Jonathan Wilkinson told POLITICO that, despite his country’s rigorous forestry practices, it will still face “all of these burdensome requirements in terms of geolocation … that actually cost enormous amounts of money.”

Pushing back: “The EUDR is about protecting forests … It is not about making diapers more expensive for European families,” said Commission spokesperson Anna-Kaisa Itkonen. “Since the regulation entered into force in June 2023, the Commission has worked closely with industry and stakeholders to keep implementation practical, proportionate and cost-efficient, while minimizing compliance costs.”

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

STEPPING ON THE GAS: A rise in U.S. gas exports to the Western Balkans has sparked fears that the region could end up dependent on American fossil fuels and undermine the transition to clean energy, Ben Munster reports from Vienna.

HOW RUSSIA'S WAR CAME TO LATIN AMERICA: Moscow is casting a wider net in its latest recruitment drives, drafting young soldiers across Latin America to fuel its full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

BETTER TIES: The U.K. and EU will deepen cooperation on foreign aid , with London sending its development minister to an EU Council meeting next month for the first time since Brexit.

About that Brexit reset: Brussels has warned Andy Burnham's government that the U.K. will need to raise tariffs on Chinese cars and to align more closely with its trade policy if it wants to avoid "Made in Europe" barriers, the FT reports .

BIBI FUMES: Benjamin Netanyahu praised Donald Trump and berated his adversaries in a speech at UNGA last night, accusing New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani of antisemitism and lashing out at France and Britain for their "hypocrisy" toward Israel.

THE TRUTH ABOUT UNGA: The U.N. General Assembly is a bit like Christmas with the extended family, Paul Dallison writes in his latest Declassified column: Hour after hour of extreme tedium, punctuated by the occasional offensive outburst or fistfight .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny and warm. High of 24C.

THE MOST MYSTERIOUS JOB IN TOWN: A new role is on offer for those wanting to advise a foreign government. Which government? That's none of your business.

Apply first, ask questions later: A job ad for a trade policy adviser at an unnamed Brussels diplomatic mission has caught the bubble's attention. One curious Playbook reader asked who was hiring — only to be told the mission had specifically requested anonymity. "I'm unfortunately not able to share which government or diplomatic mission is behind this vacancy," came the reply, seen by Playbook.

Nothing to see here: Belgian recruitment rules require that information is given about the job, but don't expressly say the employer has to identify itself. That leaves Brussels' aspiring trade wonks with an unusual proposition: Hand over your CV, career history and expertise to an unidentified foreign government — and perhaps find out who it is later. What could possibly go wrong? Deadline for applications, if you're brave enough, is Oct. 15.

SPEAKING OF JOBS: It's time for Playbook's monthly roundup of weird vacancies — your regular reminder that EU careers are considerably stranger than their reputation suggests.

To infinity and beyond: The EU Agency for the Space Programme is looking for a space market officer in Prague. Apparently the EU space market is significant enough that somebody gets to have this as their actual job title. Applications close Oct. 20.

Are we human or are we officials? In Cologne, the EU Aviation Safety Agency wants a human factors expert — essentially someone paid to worry about how humans interact with cockpits, controls and increasingly clever aircraft. Deadline: Oct. 19.

Chair Force One: Playbook's favorite is the Commission's hunt in Luxembourg for a team leader for "Moves, Inventory and Furniture." Translation: When Eurocrats change floors, somebody has to make sure the desks, chairs and cupboards arrive with them — and apparently lead a team doing it. Hurry as applications close Sept. 28.

Meanwhile, at the EEAS: The diplomatic service is recruiting a space threat response duty officer — difficult to read without hearing dramatic movie-trailer music — and a head of intelligence hub in Ukraine.

BRUSSELS ON A BUDGET: For many, payday hasn't arrived yet. So here's Playbook's guide to a (nearly) zero-budget Brussels weekend:

Market therapy: The Marolles street market runs Saturday and Sunday. Free to browse, plenty of atmosphere and cheap-ish food if temptation strikes.

Design for free: "Curated" at Mix Brussels runs Friday through Sunday inside the former Royale Belge building, showcasing collectible design. Entry is free; brunch and cocktails are available for those willing to break the spending freeze.

Plant, don't spend: The "Jardins de l'Hippodrome" festival brings plants, workshops and forest walks to Boitsfort this weekend. Entry is free. Buying a plant isn't.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: A special meeting of Berlin's Left Party is being keenly watched for signs of whether it can be a credible coalition partner.

Paris: Emmanuel Macron told French TV networks last night he'll focus on securing fuel supplies in the Middle East to ease prices at the pump, rather than cutting taxes.

London: Andy Burnham faces a day of intense media scrutiny in preparation for the Labour Party conference, with at least 27 interviews in his diary.

Washington: Senate Republicans are feeling the heat over rising living costs with just a week left before they break for the midterms.

Ottawa: Conservatives face a crossroads on labor as Mark Carney's government pushes its "build, baby, build" bill.

Canberra: The OpenAI Medicare hack has set off a political explosion — but it's less clear who will take responsibility for the fallout.

Join us in Brussels this November for a conversation about Europe's direction and priorities. Follow the conversation at the European Pulse Seminar , hear from key decision-makers and share your views on the challenges and opportunities ahead. Apply to join .

AGENDA

— U.N. General Assembly continues in New York.

— Commission Executive Vice President Stéphane Séjourné visits Luxembourg, where he tours Hydro's Clervaux aluminum plant with Defense Minister Yuriko Backes at 9 a.m.; meets Economy Minister Lex Delles at 1:30 p.m. (joint press conference at 2:15 p.m.); meets Prime Minister Luc Frieden at 2:30 p.m.; and has an audience with Grand Duke Guillaume at 3:15 p.m.

— Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen is in Greenland, where she meets Prime Minister Jens-Frederik Nielsen.

— Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius holds a meeting on the Azores Space Port.

— Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis participates in a simplification event at the University of Latvia in Riga, with a keynote conversation on EU simplification at 1 p.m. Watch live .

— Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen meets Italian Agriculture Minister Francesco Lollobrigida.

— Internal Affairs Commissioner Magnus Brunner visits the Bavarian State Police's Drone Competence and Defense Center in Erding.

— Crisis Management Commissioner Hadja Lahbib meets U.N. humanitarian chief Tom Fletcher in New York; meets U.N. High Commissioner for Refugees Barham Salih; and delivers a statement on behalf of EU member countries at a high-level meeting on pandemic preparedness.

— Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica meets Jasem Mohamed AlBudaiwi, secretary-general of the Cooperation Council for the Arab States of the Gulf, in New York.

BIRTHDAYS

Celebrating Friday: MEP Pascal Arimont; former MEP (and grandson of the president) Charles de Gaulle; former MEPs Maria João Rodrigues and Charles Tannock; Alpeggiani Avvocati Associati's Martino Liva; TW Visual Storytelling Agency's Jack Zahora.

Celebrating Saturday: Former MEP Thijs Berman; Eubelius' Hans Plancke; European Commission's Chantal Hughes; Ukraine's former President Petro Poroshenko; Google's Karen Massin; Rud Pedersen Public Affairs' Nicholas Lunt; academic David Livingstone Smith.

Celebrating Sunday: MEP Aldo Patriciello; former MEPs Jessica Stegrud, Gabriele Preuß, Agustín Díaz de Mera García Consuegra and Christelle Lechevalier; EEAS' David Ringrose; Radio Free Europe's Pablo Gorondi; EU Ambassador to the Democratic Republic of the Congo Douglas Carpenter; The Brussels Times' Dennis Abbott; strategic communications adviser Elizabeth Boswell Rega; former president of Cyprus Nicos Anastasiades; Süddeutsche Zeitung's Gabriel Rinaldi; European Parliament's Dovilė Sandaraitė. French Community Day in Belgium.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Google:** Google has opened Connected Cup, an AI pop-up in the Brussels EU Quarter. Three weeks still to run. It offers hands-on demos of AI tools from Google and partners, alongside engaging workshops, social events, and conversations with Europe's innovators and thinkers

on artificial intelligence. But human connection, fuelled by excellent coffee, is the point. Open to everyone at Rue d'Arlon, 80, from 21 September to 16 October, weekdays 08:00 to 16:00. Explore the full programme , register for upcoming sessions, or stop by for coffee and conversation.**

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